capital development. Ultimately, Burma could not transform a backward agrarian society into a modern state with a balanced economy.

By mid 1957, U Nu admitted that numerous mistakes had been made in the initial plans to form a socialist economic system. Consequences of these early blunders included a lack of a coherent production plan for materials being ordered; preordering of machinery that was delivered prior to having a place to house it; a flawed accounting system to calculate a cost-benefit analysis. The role of the caretaker government under Ne Win would alter the economy in significant ways.

THE ROLE OF BUDDHISM IN POSTINDEPENDENT BURMA

U Nu was a devote Buddhist who wanted to create a bridge between religion and the state. Burmese scholars believe that U Nu may have moved in a more religious direction publicly after the split with the more leftist elements within Burma. The concept of nationalism through Buddhism may have been appealing to many within the governing elite in Burma.

Michael Charney, author of *A History of Burma*, believes three variables impacted Nu's decision to adapt a more public advocacy of Buddhism. First, Nu sincerely believed in the concept of merit being vital to a Buddhist society. Second, monks were becoming much more politically active in the post–World War II period. Many monks pushed for a designation of Buddhism as the official state religion. Finally, Buddhism was a way to counter the growth of radical communism in Burma (Charney 88–90).

The push for Buddhism began with the state attempting to control the structure and function of faith within society. The Vinasaya Act of 1949 dealt with monastic infractions as well as registering and monitoring behavior. Furthermore, U Nu set up Buddhist universities and encouraged missionary activities. Finally, the World Peace pagoda was constructed as well as the large man-made cave known as the Maha Pasana Guha. Nu went to the extreme of hosting and promoting the Sixth World Buddhist Council, which commemorated the 2,500th anniversary of the Buddha's attainment of nirvana. The hosting of the council may have actually resurrected the idea of making Buddhism the state religion of Burma.